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Prejudice, Types and Origins of

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INTRODUCTION

Prejudices are ubiquitous. In the fifth round of the World Values Survey, carried out between 2005 and 2008, 44% of the respondents from 57 countries from around the world agreed or agreed strongly that “men make better political leaders than women do,” and 53% said they did not trust very much or did not trust at all “people of another nationality.” In the fourth round of the European Social Survey, carried out in 2008 and 2009, 16% of the respondents from 17 European countries disagreed or disagreed strongly that “gay men and lesbians should be free to live their own life as they wish,” and 48% tended to agree that “people over 70 are a burden on the country’s health service these days.” Prejudiced attitudes such as these have negative social and health consequences for members of the targeted groups. They also have negative consequences for societies as a whole because they impair social interactions and undermine the positive contributions of groups to societies. Prejudices can translate into actual discriminatory and violent behavior, further aggravating these negative consequences. (See discrimination.) If prejudices are widely shared in a culture, they represent cultural violence, legitimating and facilitating individual and collective oppression and violence. Against this background, it is not

surprising that the body of research on prejudice is immense.

DEFINITIONS OF PREJUDICE

Numerous attempts have been made to define prejudice. Most of these definitions see prejudice as a negative attitude toward a particular social group and its individual members. Individual members are *prejudged* because of their group membership. Prejudice is linked to, but can be distinguished from, stereotypes (which are typically defined as beliefs about the characteristics of typical members of a group) and discrimination (which is typically defined as negative behavior toward a group and its members). (See stereotypes; discrimination.)

A classic question is whether *any* or only an *illegitimately* negative attitude to a particular group and its members should be regarded as prejudice. Is it prejudice if someone shows strong negativity to the Ku Klux Klan? Because legitimacy judgments always depend on one’s perspective in a certain social context, it seems useful to define prejudice simply as a negative attitude. This does not mean that the concept of prejudice is simple. Rather, it involves numerous complexities.

Research on prejudice can be group specific or “general.” Group-specific research examines prejudice toward a particular target group, focusing on the specific cities involved. Typical target groups include women, immigrants and asylum seekers, gay men and lesbians, and the elderly – as alluded to in the introduction – as well as Jews, Blacks, long-term unemployed people, and people with physical or mental disabilities. (See

racism ; xenophobia ; anti-semitism , psychology of ; asylum seekers and refugees , attitudes toward .) “ General ” research on prejudice, in contrast, focuses on the generic social psychological processes involved in any kind of prejudice.

TYPES OF PREJUDICE

Cognition, Affect, and Behavioral Tendencies

Just like attitudes in general, prejudice involves cognitive, affective, and behavioral aspects. The cognitive aspect concerns evaluative beliefs about characteristics of the group in question or its members; the affective aspect concerns emotional reactions; and the behavioral aspect refers to tendencies or intentions to show discriminatory behavior.

Stereotypical beliefs refer to two main evaluative dimensions: warmth and competence (Cuddy, Fiske, & Glick, 2008). The warmth dimension comprises traits such as morality, sincerity, and kindness, while the competence dimension includes traits such as efficacy, confidence, and intelligence. Thus, prejudice can be expressed by seeing a group and its members as cold and hostile, as incompetent and weak, or as negative on both dimensions. Some research suggests further differentiations of the two dimensions. Stereotypes on the warmth dimension include perceptions of sociability and morality, and stereotypes on the competence dimension include perceptions of ability and status.

Emotional reactions refer to negative and positive affect as well as specific emotions. Prejudice can be reflected in the presence of negative affect as well as in the absence of positive affect. Another

approach, going beyond positivity and negativity, is to distinguish between specific emotions involved in prejudice. Research has examined, for example, feelings of anxiety, disgust, pity, and envy toward groups and their members. (See emotions in violence and peace , intergroup .)

Behavioral tendencies include approach and avoidance tendencies, or tendencies to discriminate in the form of commission (giving out negative stimuli) and omission (withholding positive stimuli). Negative approach tendencies refer to various forms of active behavior such as harassment, physical violence, and anti - locution (a mild form of hate speech). Negative avoidance tendencies refer to various forms of passive behavior such as neglect, withholding social support, avoiding intimacy, and preserving social distance from a group and its members.

PERSONAL VS. COLLECTIVE ASPECTS OF PREJUDICE

As described so far, prejudice concerns how people as individuals evaluate, how they perceive, feel about, and tend to behave toward, individual members of a target group. This personal focus of prejudice has been criticized as it seems to limit the usefulness of the concept of prejudice to the understanding of political and societal processes. Going beyond this personal focus, however, prejudice also has collective aspects. These collective aspects concern how people as group members perceive, feel about, and tend to behave toward the target group in terms of the group ’ s relation to society.

In the cognitive domain, while personal aspects of prejudice include warmth and competence stereotypes, collective aspects

include beliefs about whether the target group facilitates or violates cherished values, customs, and traditions. In the affective domain, while personal aspects refer to an individual's emotional reactions (e.g., feeling anxious anticipating an interpersonal interaction), collective aspects include feelings based on the target group's position in society (e.g., feelings of collective threat related to economic competition or differences in cultural values and worldviews). In the behavioral domain, while personal aspects include interpersonal approach and avoidance tendencies, collective aspects include tendencies to act collectively such as supporting political persecution, exclusion, or other discriminatory policies (e.g., demanding that immigrants assimilate rather than integrate).

PREJUDICE SYNDROMES

Cognitive, affective, and behavioral as well as personal and political aspects of prejudice do not exist in isolation, but form prejudice syndromes. For example, different combinations of warmth and competence stereotypes are related to the emotions of admiration, contempt, envy, and pity, as well as different active or passive behavioral tendencies (Cuddy et al., 2008). Particular prejudice syndromes tend to be developed in response to particular groups and particular activating conditions (Schaller & Neuberg, 2008).

Some of these syndromes have received specific research attention. For example, "modern racism" includes negative affect and perceived violations of cherished values such as individualism. Also, while "blatant prejudice" includes perceived threat, belief in inferiority of the target

group, and opposition to intimate contact, "subtle prejudice" includes perceived violations of cherished values, exaggeration of cultural differences, and absence of positive feelings toward the group.

EXPLICIT AND IMPLICIT PREJUDICE

With concepts such as modern racism and subtle prejudice, researchers have taken into account that egalitarian social norms, whether internalized or not, often prevent prejudice from being expressed blatantly (Walker, 2001). Taking this notion further, some aspects of prejudice may even be automatic and unavailable to human consciousness. Accordingly, explicit (controlled) prejudice can be distinguished from implicit (automatic) prejudice. While explicit prejudice refers to the conscious aspects of cognition, affect, and behavioral tendencies as described above, implicit prejudice consists of associative links between the mental representation of a social group and negative stereotypes, affect, or behavioral tendencies. Building on this distinction, "aversive racism" has been conceptualized as combining a conscious endorsement of egalitarian principles with unconscious negative feelings and beliefs about Blacks. To measure implicit associations, a variety of methods such as the Implicit Association Test and affective priming have been developed (De Houwer, Teige-Mocigemba, Spruyt, & Moors, 2009).

ORIGINS OF PREJUDICE

In explaining the origins or causes of prejudice, social scientists have focused on four important issues: (1) what universal social or psychological factors are

responsible for the ubiquity of prejudice in human societies; (2) what social and intergroup processes result in certain groups and not others becoming particular targets for prejudice; (3) what individual characteristics result in certain people being generally prejudiced toward other groups and others less so; (4) why are certain societies, cultures, or social groups more prejudiced or ethnocentric than others?

Universal Social Psychological Bases of Prejudice

Sumner (1906) argued that the mere division of the social world into discrete groups would inevitably generate a universal syndrome of ethnocentrism that combines attachment to one's own group with prejudice toward other groups. (See ethnocentrism .) Today, researchers believe that Sumner's thesis was overgeneralized and that ethnocentrism is not an inevitable concomitant of group differentiation. Nevertheless, the ubiquity of prejudice suggests that certain universal human processes do predispose people to prejudice. Research in the social identity tradition suggests that positivity toward one's own group can arise from mere perception of group differentiation. (See social identity theory .) Simply categorizing people as members of one's own social category or as members of another social category seems to automatically generate identification with one's group and a motivational tendency to positively differentiate it from other groups through bias, favoritism, and discrimination.

Social identity theory has tended to see the intergroup bias and discrimination triggered by mere categorization as a rudimentary form of prejudice. However,

this bias primarily comprises enhanced positivity to one's own group rather than negativity to other groups, suggesting social categorization may be a precursor which is elaborated into prejudice toward other groups only under certain social and intergroup conditions. Thus, while tendencies to favor and identify with one's own group may be universal, intergroup prejudice is not a universal consequence. What social and intergroup conditions influence whether social categorization develops into prejudice toward certain groups but not toward others?

Social and Intergroup Origins of Prejudice

Prejudiced attitudes are typically widely shared or consensual within collectives and directed against certain groups and not others. This consensuality or normativity may be due to particular relationships or conditions of contact and interaction between groups. Research has focused on four kinds of intergroup relationships that seem particularly conducive to prejudice against specific groups. These four factors are convergent group boundaries, intergroup competition, intergroup threat, and intergroup inequality; they are not independent and can mutually influence one another.

When groups are characterized by convergent boundaries – the coincidence of many possible distinctions, such as ethnicity, language, religion, social class, urban or rural residence, political affiliation – social categorization is highly salient and pervasive. In such conditions, group distinctions and differences will be accentuated. Moreover, cross-cutting group categorizations, a common superordinate categorization, and opportunities for individuated contact and

interaction with members of the other group – factors which all contribute to reducing prejudice – will be limited or absent. (See contact theory, intergroup; common ingroup identity model.)

The role of intergroup competition in causing prejudice was first experimentally demonstrated in classic research showing that organizing a competitive tournament between groups of American boys at summer camps transformed attitudes between these groups from relative harmony to fierce antagonism. (See intergroup conflict, theories of.) Setting these groups to work together repeatedly on cooperative tasks markedly reduced this hostility. Intergroup competition does not need to be over material issues such as economic resources, welfare, and power, but can also be over relative status and prestige.

A third factor causing prejudice toward particular groups is intergroup threat, where members of one group see another group (or subgroup) as a source of harm or disruption to their own group. (See intergroup threat theory; threat, kinds and effects of.) Different kinds of intergroup threat such as realistic threat (to physical safety or material resources), symbolic threat (to worldviews, values, and beliefs), and group esteem threat (to positive social identity) have all been shown to predict prejudice (Riek, Mania, & Gaertner, 2006). These threats can, but do not necessarily, derive from intergroup competition. Evolutionary theories have suggested that prejudice in reaction to perceived threat may constitute an adaptive response that has had survival value for groups in the past (Schaller & Neuberg, 2008).

A fourth factor conducive to prejudice is that of intergroup inequality. When

groups are of unequal status or power, and particularly when one group has a dominant position relative to another, research has shown that members of the dominant group often derogate members of the subordinate group and stereotype them as incompetent. Different theories have emphasized different motives and mechanisms for this, such as dominant group members' desire to justify, maintain, and reassert their relative superiority (see social dominance theory) or a desire to avoid disruptive social change and the tendency to attribute traits to people consistent with their social roles and status (see system justification theory). Intergroup inequality can also generate "envious prejudice" in low-status groups toward higher-status groups, whose higher ranking is seen as illegitimate and capable of being changed.

Individual Differences in Prejudice

Although prejudice toward particular groups is typically widely shared within a collective, there is also considerable variation in the degree to which individuals within this collective hold these prejudiced attitudes. Moreover, individuals who are prejudiced toward particular groups are often also prejudiced toward other groups – a phenomenon known as the generality of prejudice.

How can these individual differences in prejudice be explained? A considerable body of research has addressed this question by examining their correlates.

A number of individual difference variables have been shown to correlate significantly with prejudice. The most prominent are cognitive style factors (rigidity, and needs for structure, closure, and certainty), broad personality traits (low openness to experience and low agree

ableness), social worldview beliefs (dangerous- world beliefs, belief in a competitive - jungle world), personal values (conservation and self - enhancement values), and the two ideological attitude dimensions of right - wing authoritarianism (RWA) and social dominance orientation (SDO). However, when all these factors were used simultaneously to predict prejudice, only the two ideological attitudes of RWA and SDO remained strong and significant predictors. This suggests that RWA (a combination of traditionalism, support for authorities, and favoring coercive social control) and SDO (support for intergroup inequality, hierarchy, and group dominance) are the major proximal individual difference determinants of prejudice. Effects of other psychological variables seem to be either spurious or mediated via RWA and SDO. (See authoritarian personality ; social dominance theory .)

The issue of how these psychological variables are interrelated in determining prejudice in individuals has been addressed by a dual process motivational model which posits a particular developmental sequence leading to prejudice (Duckitt, 2001). The model sees prejudice as directly determined by RWA and SDO, which in turn are influenced by people 's social worldview beliefs and personalities. RWA (viewed as the attitudinal expression of collective security goals and conservation values) is influenced by dangerous- world beliefs, and both dangerous -world beliefs and RWA are influenced by the personality trait of low openness. SDO (viewed as the attitudinal expression of power and dominance goals and self - enhancement values) is influenced by people 's beliefs that their social world is a competitive jungle, which in turn

is influenced by the personality trait of low agreeableness.

Cultural and Societal Bases of Prejudice

Finally, cross - cultural research has shown that prejudice can also be a societal or cultural phenomenon, with certain societies or cultures being generally less tolerant than others. For example, Bond (1988) investigated 21 cultures and found that they were differentiated along a cultural value dimension ranging from cultural inwardness and superiority at one end to generalized tolerance for and harmony with others at the other. (See national political cultures .)

However, there has been little research on what causes societies or cultures to be ethnocentric. Some evidence suggests that preindustrial cultures were more ethnocentric and conflict - prone to the extent that they were characterized by relatively harsh, punitive, and unaffectionate childhood socialization, possibly creating a psychological disposition to react to others with distrust and hostility. The dual process motivational explanation for individual differences in prejudice points to social environmental circumstances in a society, such as high levels of threat and danger as well as inequality and competition. Social representations of these circumstances may result in the values and attitudes of RWA and SDO, respectively, becoming culturally dominant and normative. This would result in more ethnocentric and intolerant societies.

TOWARD AN INTEGRATIVE VIEW

Social scientific research has focused on four different but complementary

questions about prejudice. Taken together, this work suggests that certain universal social psychological factors create a basic disposition in humans to differentiate their own groups positively from others. This disposition translates into prejudice toward particular groups under certain social and intergroup circumstances such as convergent boundaries, intergroup competition, threat, and inequality. The degree to which individuals perceive the social and intergroup situation in such terms is modulated by their social worldview beliefs, personal values, and the ideological attitudes of RWA and SDO. These individual characteristics in turn seem to be shaped by cultural factors such as childhood socialization patterns as well as social representations of danger, competition, and inequality in society. It seems, then, that the development of a coherent, integrative framework for the understanding of prejudice is becoming increasingly feasible.

CONCLUSIONS AND FUTURE DIRECTIONS

Throughout this essay it has been evident that prejudice is a very complex phenomenon. First, the concept itself comprises cognitive, affective, and behavioral domains as well as personal and political aspects. Our discussion of the origins of prejudice disregarded this complexity and treated different prejudice syndromes in an undifferentiated way. It is likely, however, that different explanations pertain more to certain prejudice aspects or syndromes than to others; for example, social and intergroup approaches may explain collective aspects of prejudice better than personal aspects. This problem may be especially relevant for implicit

prejudice because most of the origins of prejudice we highlighted have been investigated mainly with regard to explicit prejudice. Second, the explanations of prejudice refer to multiple levels of analysis – individual, group, and societal – which need to be integrated into a coherent framework. Although social psychology is well placed to take different levels of analysis into account, this integration remains a major methodological and theoretical challenge.

SEE ALSO: Anti-Semitism, Psychology of; Asylum Seekers and Refugees, Attitudes toward; Authoritarian Personality; Common Ingroup Identity Model; Contact Theory, Intergroup; Discrimination; Emotions in Violence and Peace, Intergroup; Ethnocentrism; Intergroup Conflict, Theories of; Intergroup Threat Theory; National Political Cultures; Racism; Social Dominance Theory; Social Identity Theory; Stereotypes; System Justification Theory; Threat, Kinds and Effects of; Xenophobia.

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ADDITIONAL RESOURCES

- Brown, R. J. (2010). *Prejudice: Its social psychology* (2nd ed.). Oxford, UK: Wiley-Blackwell.
- <http://www.understandingprejudice.org/> (website with more than 2,000 links to prejudice-related resources, databases with hundreds of prejudice researchers and social justice organizations, and interactive exercises on prejudice, stereotyping, and discrimination)
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